

AFP PHOTO/RAVEENDRAN



BACKTRACKING:
Advani with Bhutto

What caused this sudden U-turn is the furore the book has created in the PPP which the late Benazir headed. Senator Farhatullah Babar, PPP spokesperson and a close Benazir aide in a letter to Advani said the book was full of "false scurrilous and defamatory statements about Benazir". Two examples from Babar: "The author claims without offering a shred of evidence that Benazir was madly in love with two Pakistani students during her Oxford days" and "without quoting any source, he says that Benazir had all her body hair 'plucked' the night before her marriage. Could there be anything more in bad taste than this?" he asked.

While such salacious details may well help the book's sales, it's taken for granted that this is one book that Advani will certainly not bother to read.

by Priya Sahgal

Hindsight Forethought

DELHI There is something about the land of his birth that always lands Lal Krishna Advani into embarrassment, if not trouble. Three years ago, he lost the presidentship of the BJP after his first visit to Pakistan after the Partition. At the Jinnah Mausoleum in Karachi, he

sang paens in praise of the country's founder, calling him "secular", enraging his party colleagues.

Last week, another Karachi connection left the Leader of the Opposition red faced. Advani had formally launched the book *Goodbye Shahzadi*,

authored by London-based journalist Shyam Bhatia, who claims close personal ties with the late Pakistan People's Party (PPP) leader Benazir Bhutto. Now Advani says he "regrets having attended the function. Had I read the book, I would not have gone for its launch".

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

Retired bureaucrats and some facing impending retirement have never been so hyperactive. With about eight governors due to demit office in the near future, hectic lobbying is on to grab the plum posts in the best of the Raj Bhavans.

VOICES



"We seek a world in which power flows from the strength and resilience of our economy, our society, the people, our institutions and our values."

Manmohan Singh, prime minister

"The UPA Government cannot reach a decision. I wish L.K. Advani becomes India's next prime minister as he is the only one who can take a decision and hang me."

Mohammad Afzal, sentenced to death in the December 2001 Parliament attack case

"It is women's right to get 33 per cent seats as they constitute half the country's population. Even 60 years after Independence, their representation is woefully inadequate."

Somnath Chatterjee, Lok Sabha speaker

"Merely 5 per cent of 25 lakh of the Gujjar community was indulging in violence and arson to demand their inclusion in the ST category, which is totally unjustified."

K.S. Sudarshan, Rashtriya Swayamsewak Sangh chief

"I lost 35 kg for my first film. Even if I starve myself I'd never be a size zero. But I believe there's nothing like being too successful or too thin."

Sonam Kapoor, actor

